

KF10 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Dr. Thorndyke, a character in detective fiction created about a hundred years ago, defined mindfulness as *the capacity for continuous observation and a habit of allowing nothing to pass without a certain amount of conscious attention*.¹ In KF, we begin our mindfulness training by observing our breath. Then, as we continue to train, we learn to expand our capacity for continuous observation to include everything, both within and without, as we go through our day.

Centuries ago, some jealous teachers questioned a great teacher about the difference between his disciples and theirs. They said, “Our disciples walk, and so do yours. They eat, as yours do. What is the difference?” The great teacher answered, “This is the difference. My disciples *know* that they are walking and they *know* that they are eating.”² By this he meant that his disciples were consciously aware of their movements and choices. They had learned to stop damaging things, forgetting things, going on autopilot, and messing things up, because they had learned the habit of allowing nothing to pass without a certain amount of conscious attention. We can learn to live like that, too.

Let’s practice the **Maranatha Meditation**.³

Begin by sitting still and as upright as you can. Breathe as you lightly close your eyes. *(Pause)* Your mind may not be focused right now, but don’t worry about that. It’s better to try to meditate and to do it imperfectly than to give up meditation because you can’t do it without some frustration. Meditation is a discipline that requires training and practice. Be kind to yourself as a learner.

Continue your mindful observation of the breath as within yourself you begin to say the word MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA. If your mind wanders, gently draw it back to the word and the breath. *(Pause)* To help you endure, I will remind you of the word once during our three-minute meditation. Begin, and relax into the word as you breathe. *(Pause for 3 minutes with a reminder of the word after 1.5 minutes)*

And pause. Your breath can function as an anchor to bring you into a present state of awareness without judgment. The **Maranatha Meditation** trains your mind to stop dashing around out of fear or euphoria.

You learn to take charge of your body and your mind when your Idol Self feels the compelling need to fulfill its search for glory.

Our hymn and prayer is *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord*.

Long as my life shall last, teach me Thy way!
Where'er my lot be cast, teach me Thy way!
Until the race is run, until the journey's done,
Until the crown is won, teach me Thy way!⁴

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by the Creator.

Over the past few weeks, we have been looking at the **Two Paths Flowchart**. This tool helps us think through how we, or others, are handling an event. If we have taken the judgment path, we have reacted with fear, but it might not feel like fear at the time. Fear might feel like fatigue, rage, or an addictive compulsion. When examining your experiences and reactions, it is important to remember that the event itself is not causing the fear. The event is only revealing the fear that is already there, the fear that you already carry. I have designed a guide called the **Two Paths Worksheet** to help you apply the flowchart to an event. You might like to print it out and explore it this week.

Without training, we default to the path of judgment when threatened. We are then unable to think or make a rational choice. We just react, usually in habitual ways, but these habitual reactions are not trustworthy. They are not based on truth or love; they are based on fear. When fear rules our lives, we cannot trust ourselves, nor can others trust us—and God certainly cannot trust us to handle the delicate role of being His ambassadors in this world. So, if we want to become trustworthy, we must unload our fear.

As we learn to recognize and unload our fears, we become more and more aware of the areas where we cannot trust ourselves. You might review the chapter on your Idol type in Dr. Horney's book, as well as chapters 12–16, to help you identify the situations that tempt you to react with fear, making you untrustworthy. See if you can correlate your fears to your Idol type. Look those fears in the face and observe how your Idol perpetuates them in order to hold you in a persistently reactive state. Your fear reactions are based on your personal law, your "Ten Commandments". They are the shoulds, taboos, and claims that enslave you to the fear of death. God's commandments are healthy and support your true glory, but your personal commandments compel you to save your Idol's life and, with it, your pride. If you do not train yourself, you will not be able to recognize your internal legal system. Your Idol Self needs to keep you blind to your personal commandments so that you will unconsciously act upon them by default. In this way, the Idol maintains control and keeps driving you down the path of judgment toward its

idealized glory. You are in KF because you now want to reclaim the treasure of the glory that has been stolen from you by your Idol's fear.

The root of all fear is the fear of death. Over the years, I have observed that this fear falls into three general categories: the fear of self, the fear of others, and the fear of loss, including the loss of control.

First, we fear ourselves. We fear that something is wrong with us and that this fundamental wrongness will inexorably ruin our lives. William James presents the fear of self like this: "The uneasiness, reduced to its simplest terms, is a sense that there is something wrong about us as we naturally stand."⁵ We might try to assuage this sense of innate wrongness by judging others and asserting that they are wrong so that we can feel right about ourselves. I believe that we can see this disturbing dynamic in King Saul's hostility toward David and, also, in Saul of Tarsus' persecution of the early church. For thousands of years, this wrongness, or flaw, has been agonizingly portrayed in tragic stories and drama. There are many examples of both historical and literary figures who make choices that reveal how innately wrong they are. In the world of literature, this inability to succeed because something is lacking within the hero is called the *fatal flaw*. The hero's fatal flaw is something that we can relate to. Deep down, we know that we have the power to ruin our lives, but the most destructive flaw is to believe that we cannot help it. The truth is that we actually can make choices that will produce positive outcomes.

This group expressed the fear of self in terms of not knowing how to handle things, missing out on what life and God have to offer, and being terrified of our potential. We fear undermining ourselves or damaging others. We fear that we cannot trust ourselves and that we will not be able to live in the peace and joy that God has promised us. We fear that we will allow ourselves to be seduced by the illusions of our Idol Self and will, therefore, never be able to connect to God.

Second, we fear people, God, or institutions that oppress, abandon, or obstruct. We fear that their choices may distress or harm us. We are afraid of being accused, shamed, rejected, or controlled. We feel acute anxiety when others seem stronger, better, smarter, or more attractive than we are. We fear that people may not value us enough to obey us or may not want to be with us. We are terrified that others will not support our compulsive need to fulfill our imagined glory. We are afraid that they will attack us if we try to live our true life. We fear that they will judge our progress or lack of it. We are afraid that they will find us unacceptable, or, perhaps even worse, we fear that they will simply not care.

The last general category of fear is the fear of loss. We may fear the loss of a loving relationship, a life-style, freedom, control, wealth of any kind, or even the loss of a sense of superiority. We are terrified of losing whatever our Idol Self values, whether mastery, love, or freedom. We fear the death of hopes and dreams, and we fear the loss of control, security, self-esteem, and affection. We fear losing things and people that we have worked for and invested in, things and people that we love. We are afraid that time and resources will be stolen from us. We fear the loss of our true potential.

You might also consider what your family taught you about fear. What did your family fear and how did they deal with it? The answer to these questions might give you some insight into how you unconsciously handle your own fear. Most of us are oblivious to our fears. That's why events are so valuable. Like a faithful compass or bird dog, events point out to us what we really fear.

Although we all experience the same basic fears of self, of others, and of loss, what we fear may vary at different ages and life stages. Most of the fears that KF members identified were fears of self. This is quite typical of KF members and is actually quite positive. It means that you have a reasonable fear of how

powerful your choices can be. You may not know how to manage those choices right now, but you are in KF because you have hope that you can learn. You are willing to be trained and are making the effort to learn courage and endurance. You are far, far above the average person in your efforts to change your life.

God our Creator designed us to experience healthy fear to help us survive and to help us choose to obey Him. Healthy survival fears compel us to run from danger or to grab a child who is about to run into the street. The fear of the Lord motivates us to take an oriented path when we feel pressured to follow the dictates of the Idol. When we walk in the fear of the Lord, we accept His limitations for our lives and acknowledge that our choices carry real consequences that determine our outcomes.

Fear is an extremely powerful motivator, and it is the only motivator that the Idol Self knows how to use. The Idol recruits the power of fear to defend its pride and drive its search for glory. Unhealthy fear is often paralyzing, and when we are gripped by fear, we are unable to consider any evidence or exercise common sense. Over the years, your body has adapted to using fear as its primary motivator in all kinds of situations, and your biochemistry may now be stuck in patterns of chronic anxiety. You may be so accustomed to living in fear that you are afraid to give it up; the idea of a life free from fear may actually frighten you. What will help you make choices if not fear? What will you use to justify your compulsive need to attack, appease, medicate, control, or withdraw? You may tell yourself the story that your misoriented choices are motivated by common sense, justice, a real need, or Christian obedience, but, in reality, they are motivated by fear. For all of us, fear is difficult both to acknowledge and to give up.

Now that you are in training, you are no longer surprised when you feel a compelling need to escape fear and save your life. Everyone experiences events, or life experiments and trials, that cause them to react because the nerve of their fear has been exposed. The first step on the path of love is to simply believe and observe, without judgment, what is happening inside you in the moment. You don't need to judge an event as good or evil, nor do you need to control, rebel, or appease. Just by acknowledging your fear, you have begun to take the path of love. So, with compassion for yourself, simply believe that you have these fears. Appreciate their power and then choose to practice love. You can let go of control and the need to know or understand. You can let go of your ideas about how things should be and your attachment to a predicted outcome.

Continue to use the **Tapping Protocol** when you recognize that fear is motivating you. Through tapping you can relieve the aching need to fight or control, lie or apologize, escape or block. Calm your distress as you would calm a distressed child.

In our next lesson, we will learn how to use the **Two Paths Worksheet**, which helps us analyze our reactions to people and events, and guides us to creatively consider our options. You might wish to explore this worksheet with your Karis Link.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Loving Lord, help me in the moment to recognize the fear. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's look one last time at KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator.

If you have your Bible with you, turn to the second chapter of Paul's letter to the Philippians.

In this letter, Paul wants to remind us of the glory that we abandon when we choose the Idol Self over the real God. The Bible tells us what our glory looks like and feels like, and it describes the results of living in that glory, but we don't believe what the Bible says. We have not been encouraged or trained to understand that our true glory is not just for the hereafter but can be experienced now, today, here on earth. That "hereafter" story gives our Idol Self full sway in our lives. Our Idol lies to us, telling us that we cannot grow into our true glory, the glory designed for us by our Creator. It reasons that we might as well stick with the survival system that we already rely upon—a system designed for us by our Idol.

Like Israel, we have sacrificed our real potential and have chosen to worship a golden calf that we believe will lead us to glory. The problem is a little more sinister than that, however. We have imagined a glory that we think is better than the one designed for us by our Creator. We are now recognizing that the Idol Self is incapable of trusting anyone, especially our True Self, and it certainly cannot trust God or His design. Our Idol Self would rather run after a glory that seems much more glittery, easy, and self-indulgent than the one that God designed for us. It takes humility and courage to give up the pursuit of fulfilling our imagined glory and, like Jesus, to take up the form of a servant and pursue our real glory.

This is Nancy's translation with paraphrase of **Philippians 2:5–11**.

⁵Think within yourselves as Christ Jesus did, ⁶who, though in the form of God from the beginning, led the way in not grasping for that prize of equal footing with God. ⁷Instead, He stripped and emptied Himself of the form of God and took the form of a slave, becoming just like other people with creaturely limitations, and was discovered by everyone to look just like a human being. ⁸He humbled Himself, becoming obedient right up to His death, the death of the cross, perhaps the humblest death of all. ⁹Therefore, God super-exalted Him, much more than Jesus could have exalted Himself, and God *karissed* to Jesus the Name above all names; that is, His own reputation and authority, perhaps God's greatest gift, ¹⁰in order that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, the knees of every heavenly and earthly being and of those in the underworld, ¹¹and every tongue should make grateful acknowledgements, with the giving of thanks, that the Lord, the Name above all names, is Jesus Christ; and all of this adds to the glory of God the Father.

Take a deep breath.

If we will choose to cultivate the same attitude of humility that Jesus had, we can follow Him to real glory. Jesus really was God, but unlike our Idol, He did not snatch at being God. Instead, He chose to be a bondservant and allowed others to experience Him as a simple human being. If we want to follow Him, we will have to come down from the lofty illusions of our imagined glory and become obedient to God to the point of what often feels like death—for that is what it takes. Obedience will feel very much like the death of our idealized dreams of personal fulfillment, but when our training in humility is complete, we

will experience a resurrection just as Jesus did. God will take over the exalting part and will help you, even you, to become more than you ever dreamed possible. This is not just storytelling. We see it happening in Karis Fellowships every week.

We grow into our true glory and our True Self through training and intention. Have you realized yet that you were not designed to live out of the Idol Self? It is time to ask God to show you how to recover your True Self. He knows the way because He designed you, and He revealed that way in Jesus, who is *The Way*. In the New Testament Gospels, we see Jesus as the perfect example of a human being living consistently out of his True Self. God desires to reorient us to the way of Jesus so that we can discover our glorious identity as children of God.

In our last lesson, we learned that when we live out of the True Self, several things happen:

1. We live in continual correspondence, or circulation, with the created world and the Creator.
2. We become truly creative creatures who are bringing the glory of God into the material and spiritual world.
3. We explore what Paul meant when he wrote to Timothy: “The mature outcome of our message is love from a clean heart and mind, from a good moral co-understanding with God, and an authentic, active trust.”⁶

Through the Holy Spirit living in us, the True Self has been birthed by God, our true Father; and when we produce the Fruit of the Spirit in our lives, we reveal our new family heritage. We can learn to nurture the production of this Fruit just as we can learn to nurture the produce of a garden.

When fruit is ripe, the harvest feeds us and everyone around us.⁷ However, producing fruit, whether in a garden or in our lives, does not happen overnight. A harvest of fruit requires the intentional and consistent investment of preparation, training, time, and resources. The real business of the True Self is to provide an environment that eventually produces the Fruit of the Spirit in every situation. We hardly know what it is like to live a life that naturally expresses the Fruit of the Spirit, but we get to find out as we pursue training with earnest prayer and intention. What does your fruit look like? I don’t know, but I would love to find out! It will certainly look very different from mine. Each of us will produce the Fruit of the Spirit in our own unique way, but our fruit will have common characteristics, such as love, joy, and peace, which reveal our shared family heritage. You are a new creation in Christ. You are no longer compelled to conform to the world with all of its conflicts, fears, and cravings, nor are you obligated to adhere to old family systems that promote and maintain futile ways of life. You don’t have to perpetuate the fears, misoriented choices, and secrets of your forefathers.⁸ Nothing changed until Jesus came to do something new. Now, you are doing something new. It’s not easy to do new things, but nothing will change unless you do.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord and Creator, help me become something new. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider choosing to become something new. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider choosing to become something new*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you are feeling, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness, without judgment. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider becoming something new*. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider becoming something new*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what hopelessness or inspiration feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider becoming something new*. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge becoming something new as good or evil, as liberty or threat? *(Pause)* What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of loss, of others, or of yourself? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created you to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered becoming something new*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* You can observe and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe

with compassion for yourself and for others who are making an effort to become something new. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ R. Austin Freeman, *The Red Thumb Mark* (London: Collingwood Brothers, 1907), chapter XIII. Accessed 18 June, 2016, gutenberg.net.au/ebooks/c00002.html.

² Nhat Hanh, Thich. *The Long Road Turns to Joy: A Guide to Walking Meditation* (Berkeley: Parallax Press, 1996), 4.

³ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

⁴ *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* by Benjamin Mansell Ramsey (1849–1923), youtu.be/FmY6848ZQeo.

⁵ wikisource.org/wiki/Page:The_varieties_of_religious_experience,_a_study_in_human_nature.djvu/524.

⁶ 1 Tim. 1:5 (translated with paraphrase by Nancy Diven).

⁷ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁸ 2 Cor. 5:17; 1 Pet. 1:18.